

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN EQUATORIAL GUINEA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Equatorial Guinea must be approached in a way unlike almost any other nation in this series — from outside, through the world's frameworks, and with the greatest care — because it is among the most closed and repressive states on earth, where open domestic opposition is essentially impossible and gravely dangerous, and where the only levers that genuinely work are the international ones, applied from outside. This small Central African and Gulf of Guinea nation struck great reserves of offshore oil in the mid-1990s and became, on paper, one of the wealthiest states in Africa by the measure of its wealth per person; yet that wealth was captured by a tiny ruling elite while most of the population, especially on the poor and neglected mainland, remained impoverished, and the riches were spent on questionable grand projects and diverted into private assets abroad. Its environment bears the marks of that same extractive, captured system: the mainland rainforest, part of the great Congo Basin and Gulf of Guinea forests, is logged and cleared — even, in one notable case, to carve an entirely new capital out of the forest — while the coast and sea bear the pollution of oil and gas. And the oil that funded it all is now declining, a window steadily closing. There is no landmark victory at home to point to, and no one inside can safely resist. But the international levers are real.

Those who would defend Equatorial Guinea's environment and resources cannot do so at home, but the international tools are real. The distinctive one is **international anti-corruption and asset-recovery**: the wealth captured and moved abroad can be pursued through anti-corruption efforts and foreign courts, which have already reached the regime's assets overseas. The **oil and timber revenue** can be pressed toward transparency through the global resource-governance frameworks. The **Congo Basin and Gulf of Guinea rainforest**, logged and cleared, can be defended through international conservation. The **oil and gas pollution** of the coast and sea can be documented and raised through the international record. And the **world's frameworks, courts, and organisations** reach where domestic opposition cannot, while **rigorous documentation** grounds it all and needs no one inside. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Equatorial Guinea is among the most closed and repressive states on earth: open domestic opposition is impossible and gravely dangerous, so the work runs almost entirely through international channels, and anyone inside must be protected absolutely. The resource wealth has been captured by an entrenched, long-ruling elite, so change is slow and external. The oil is fading. And there is no landmark victory at home to point to. And, above all, no one inside can be exposed. So the work must be external, framed as international accountability and conservation, protecting anyone inside absolutely — and the honest prize is the captured wealth pursued, the revenue pressed toward transparency, the rainforest defended, and the pollution documented, not a project stopped from within.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot resist at home in one of the world's most repressive states, and you must never ask anyone to. What can be done is to press the captured system from outside: pursue the wealth moved abroad through international anti-corruption and asset-recovery and foreign courts, press the oil and timber revenue toward transparency, defend the rainforest through international conservation, document the coastal pollution — all through the world's frameworks, and protecting anyone inside absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Equatorial Guinea is among the most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win at home — domestic opposition is impossible and gravely dangerous. It is an external, accountability-and-conservation effort whose realistic prize is the captured wealth pursued, the revenue pressed, the rainforest defended, and the pollution documented — not a stop from within. Enter it understanding that no cause is worth a life, that the work runs through international channels alone, and that the safety of everyone inside comes before every other consideration.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with an entrenched, long-ruling elite that has captured the state and its resource wealth, in a nation where domestic opposition is impossible. The decisions resisters can reach are external — taken in the **foreign courts and anti-corruption bodies** pursuing the captured wealth, in the **global resource-transparency frameworks** that press the revenue, in the **international conservation bodies** that guard the rainforest, and in the **world's organisations and the diaspora**. These, from outside, are who can act.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The logging, the grand projects, and the oil and gas advance under the control of the captured state; there is no safe domestic hearing to contest. Resisters enter where the outside world touches the harm: the captured wealth's trail into foreign jurisdictions, the revenue's exposure through transparency frameworks, the rainforest's conservation stakes, the pollution's documentation. Each is a point of leverage reached from outside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the wealth: where the captured oil and timber money flows, which foreign assets and jurisdictions it reaches, and which anti-corruption and asset-recovery efforts can pursue it. Follow the revenue: whether the resource income is disclosed, and which transparency frameworks can press it. Follow the forest: which logging and clearance the conservation bodies can raise. The leverage lies in the asset trail, the revenue transparency, the conservation stakes, and the documented pollution.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is captured and cannot be relied upon. The watchers resisters can engage are external: the foreign courts and anti-corruption bodies, the global resource-transparency frameworks, the international conservation organisations, the human-rights and transparency bodies, and the diaspora. These are the institutions a careful, external case is built to reach.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Equatoguinean effort yields a domestic "win," and honesty requires saying so — the state and its wealth are captured, and the repression severe. What the external tools realistically deliver is accountability and defence: the captured wealth pursued and sometimes recovered abroad, the resource revenue pressed toward transparency, the rainforest watched and its clearance exposed, the coastal pollution documented before the world. The single most decisive move is **rigorous, safely-gathered documentation feeding the**

international asset-recovery, transparency, and conservation efforts, because each responds to credible evidence, and because such evidence can be gathered without endangering anyone inside. Nothing here is fast. But a captured petro-state whose wealth sits in foreign jurisdictions gives the world real handles.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the logging and forest clearance, the grand projects, the oil and gas pollution, the captured revenue. **What international lever does it touch?** — asset recovery, revenue transparency, conservation, pollution documentation. **Who outside can act?** — the foreign courts, the transparency frameworks, the conservation bodies, the diaspora. **Which external channel reaches it?** — an anti-corruption body, a transparency framework, a conservation organisation. **How is everyone inside kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping all work external and exposing no one. Pick the harm where the international handle is clearest and safest.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all gathered safely and from outside where possible. **Layer one: the harm and the capture** — the logging and clearance by satellite, the grand projects, the pollution, and the wealth captured and moved abroad. **Layer two: the framework** — the asset-recovery and anti-corruption avenues, the transparency frameworks, the conservation stakes the harm offends. **Layer three: the channel and the protection** — which external body to reach, and the absolute rule that no person inside is named, exposed, or endangered. A case built on satellite imagery, financial trails, and public records — needing no one inside — is one that reaches the levers without endangering anyone.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: satellite imagery of the logging and clearance, the grand projects, the coastal and marine pollution. Gather the **capture record**: the resource revenue, the wealth moved abroad, the foreign assets and jurisdictions, drawn from public and investigative records. Gather the **framework record**: the asset-recovery and anti-corruption avenues, the transparency frameworks, the conservation designations. Gather the **channel record**: the foreign courts, the transparency and anti-corruption bodies, the conservation organisations, the diaspora. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm every source is external and safe, and no one inside exposed.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE INTERNATIONAL AND DIASPORA COALITION

The coalition here is external, because it must be. Build it from the **international anti-corruption and asset-recovery organisations** pursuing the captured wealth; the **resource-transparency and governance frameworks** that press the revenue; the **international conservation bodies** that guard the rainforest; and the **diaspora, human-rights, and investigative networks** that document and amplify. Build carefully, protect every source and any contact inside, and never in a way that draws in or exposes anyone in the country.

STEP 4: ASSET-RECOVERY, TRANSPARENCY & CONSERVATION LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, indirect, and slow, and the state is captured, so the prize is accountability and defence, not a stop.

The Asset Recovery and Anti-Corruption

The distinctive lever is **international anti-corruption and asset-recovery**: the wealth captured and moved abroad can be pursued through anti-corruption efforts and foreign courts, which have already reached the regime's overseas assets. Trace the wealth and feed the foreign proceedings — the sharpest handle on a captured petro-state.

The Revenue Transparency and the Rainforest

The **oil and timber revenue** can be pressed toward transparency through the global resource-governance frameworks, and the **Congo Basin and Gulf of Guinea rainforest** can be defended through international conservation. Press the revenue into the light and raise the forest's clearance with the bodies that guard it.

The Pollution and the Frameworks

The **oil and gas pollution** of the coast and sea can be documented and raised, and the **world's frameworks, courts, and organisations** reach where domestic opposition cannot. Pursued together — the asset recovery, the transparency and conservation, and the documented pollution — these external levers hold the captured system to account and defend the forest, while every person inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the foreign courts and anti-corruption bodies**: here is captured wealth in your jurisdiction to pursue. **For the transparency frameworks**: here is resource revenue that must be disclosed. **For the conservation bodies**: here is a Congo Basin forest logged and cleared. **For the pollution and human-rights record**: here is the coastal harm and the captured system behind it. **The golden rule**: keep everything external and safe, argue accountability and conservation, and protect every name inside absolutely.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, carried entirely from outside. Frame the story around the **captured wealth and the threatened forest**: a petro-state's riches seized and moved abroad, a Congo Basin forest logged and cleared, a coast polluted. Carry it through international investigative, anti-corruption, and conservation outlets, and the diaspora networks. A few cautions govern everything: never name or endanger anyone inside; rely on satellite imagery, financial trails, and public records; keep it factual; and let the asset trail, the transparency failures, and the forest clearance carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, documentary, and absolutely protective of anyone inside.

8A — To a foreign anti-corruption or asset-recovery body: present the captured wealth in its jurisdiction and ask for the recovery effort.

8B — To a resource-transparency framework: set out the undisclosed oil or timber revenue and request scrutiny.

8C — To an international conservation body: document the logging or clearance of the Congo Basin forest and invoke the conservation obligation.

8D — On the pollution: document the coastal and marine oil and gas pollution and ask for it to be raised.

8E — To an investigative or human-rights organisation: present the captured system and the documented harm and request investigation.

8F — To a diaspora network: share the case and ask for amplification and safe channels.

8G — To a foreign court (through counsel): establish the asset trail into the jurisdiction.

8H — To the international public: summarise the captured wealth and the threatened forest, and ask for pressure — never exposing anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the satellite imagery of the logging or clearance and the public record of the captured wealth abroad; identify the asset-recovery, transparency, or conservation body the harm touches; write the one-page accountability-and-conservation case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the asset-recovery efforts, the transparency frameworks, and the conservation bodies. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the international anti-corruption and conservation organisations first — they act safely from outside. Throughout, expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and captured: an entrenched elite holds the state and its wealth, and domestic opposition is impossible. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a stop, but accountability and defence through the levers the capture cannot reach. Lean on the asset recovery, the transparency frameworks, the conservation bodies, and the world's courts, all pursued from outside. And accept the honest possibility of slow, partial progress — the wealth may take years to pursue, the logging may continue — while still holding the captured system to account and defending the forest, and protecting, always and above all, the people.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the corruption is not at the margins but the system: the state and its resource wealth are captured by an entrenched elite, the riches diverted into private assets abroad. Respond only through the **external channels:** the foreign courts and anti-corruption bodies, the asset-recovery efforts, the transparency frameworks, the documented record. Never through domestic action. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. Equatorial Guinea is among the most closed and repressive states on earth, where domestic opposition is impossible and any domestic voice endangered. Work through the international, diaspora, and external channels entirely; never expose or endanger anyone inside, and treat their safety as the first and overriding consideration; frame the work as international accountability and conservation; and

handle the regime only through the documented international record. Protection is not one concern among others — it is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all from outside. The documented harm and capture feed the asset recovery, the transparency pressure, and the conservation defence at once; the international and diaspora coalition organises alongside; the media carries the captured-wealth-and-forest frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the satellite documentation and the public record of the captured wealth; **months two to six**, engage the asset-recovery and anti-corruption bodies, the transparency frameworks, and the conservation organisations; **beyond**, sustain the external accountability and defence as the oil window closes. The core discipline: external, accountability-and-conservation framed, and absolute in protecting anyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Equatorial Guinea is among the most closed and captured grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a harm can be stopped from within, or that domestic opposition is possible, or that the capture is easily broken — none of that is true, and the repression is among the world's most severe. What it claims is narrower and real: that the wealth captured and moved abroad can be pursued through international anti-corruption and asset-recovery efforts and foreign courts that have already reached it; that the oil and timber revenue can be pressed toward transparency through global frameworks; that the Congo Basin rainforest can be defended through international conservation; that the coastal pollution can be documented; and that all of this can be pursued from outside, through the world's frameworks, without ever exposing a single person inside. The levers are external, slow, and partial, and the prize is accountability and defence, not a stop from within. But for a captured petro-state whose wealth sits in foreign jurisdictions and whose forest the world has reason to guard, that external, accountability-and-conservation, protective work is not a lesser ambition — it is the only responsible and effective one.